THE ACCIDENTAL ARCHITECT

Defined by material honesty and a quiet reverence for local craft, Thomas Parambil reconfigures traditional South Indian vernacular into fluid, nature-steeped sanctuaries for the contemporary soul

By **RIDHI KALE**

Photographs by JUSTIN SEBASTIAN

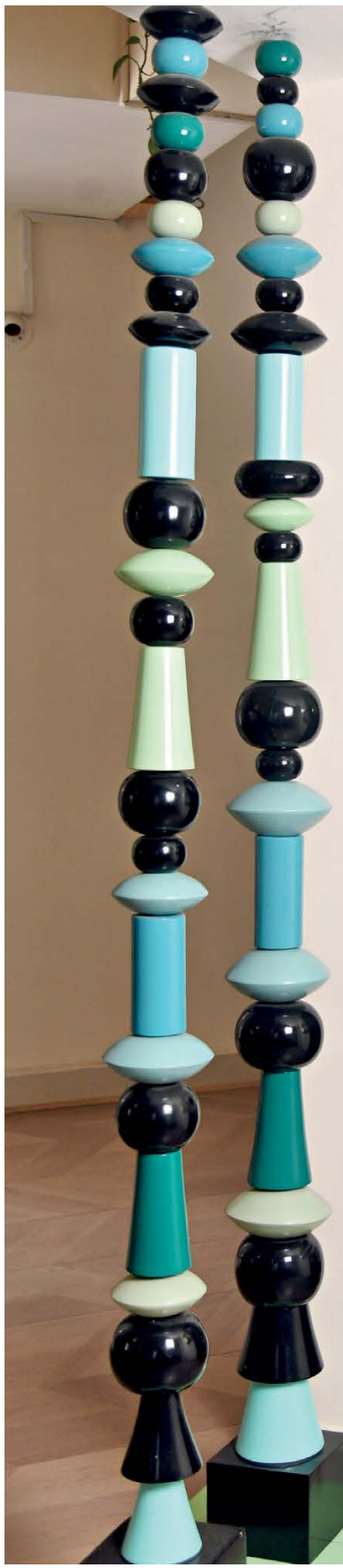
Thomas Parambil's transition from aspiring seafarer to acclaimed architect proves that the best careers are often unscripted. Since founding his studio in 2019, he has traded wanderlust for a deep-rooted obsession with space and light. It is a practice built on evolution, where every project serves as a fresh inquiry into how we live. No wonder today his studio is thriving.

High Seas to Drafting Boards

Parambil didn't set out to build homes. "I'm an accidental architect," he admits. Originally aiming for a life at sea to satisfy his wanderlust, a mother's veto and a friend's tip led him to architecture school in Mysore. While the social side of college kept him enrolled, a transformative internship with Sandeep Khosla and Amaresh Anand sparked a genuine love for the craft. What began as a whim turned into a career that launched just days after graduation and hasn't slowed down since, eventually leading him to set up Thomas Parambil Architects.

When he reimagined the humble Kerala Courtyard

A hallmark of his work, seen in projects like House of Quad and Mala House, is the seamless blend of traditional Kerala architecture with modern sensibilities. Having grown up around heritage homes, he was always drawn to the *naalukettu* (courtyard) style, but noted a recurring flaw: darkness. "The rooms often get very dark because of how the roof is handled," he explains. His approach marries traditional aesthetics with modern spatial logic. By recalibrating the proportions of slopes, verandahs and corridors, he floods spaces with light while preserving the soul of the traditional form. It isn't about building replicas; it's about solving the functional failures of the past with today's techniques.



Photograph by RATHEESH SUNDARAM